



RAMESH WITH INDIA'S SPECIAL ENVOY ON CLIMATE CHANGE SHYAM SARAN (L) AND KRISHNA (R) AT THE UN SUMMIT

The Heat IS ON

By Shafi Rahman

Even as Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh packed his bags for a pivotal climate change conference at the United Nations (UN) during the week, he unpacked plans for a domestic legislation that will quantify the emission cuts the country is prepared to make over a period of time. The legislation that will put in place a mechanism to set targets for greenhouse gas emissions will soon be tabled in Parliament. The ambitious attempt to live in a low-carbon way may win applause in the interna-

The Government's plan for legislation on greenhouse gas emissions sends political temperatures rocketing at home

tional arena but it has made the political mercury soaring back home.

"What India is going to do is to set a target date which is 2020 and introduce a quantitative outcome which is an implicit mitigation target—not an explicit target. We will enshrine that into a law so that there is a degree of credibility," Ramesh told the media. The move comes at a time when over 100 world leaders have gathered at the UN to map out energy plans and gather momentum for finalising a new global climate pact at Copenhagen in December. In his intervention at the summit, External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna noted:

"Many of the mitigation efforts in different sectors will have specific quantitative and time-bound domestic goals, with even mid-term deadlines." India's commitment won kudos at the meet from UN Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon but the Government plans have drawn flak from the political parties back home for back-flipping from the earlier stance that quantifying emission cuts is a strict no-no.

Critics of the proposed domestic legislation say that the country is buckling under pressure from the West. The US is yet to make remarkable strides in clean energy deployment and the US Congress has sent a domestic climate bill to the backburner. The US accounts for about 20 per cent of the world's greenhouse gas pollution, created when coal, natural gas or oil are burned. China generates 20 per cent, the European Union 14 per cent, and Russia and India account for 5 per cent each.

"India had always maintained that